

24 HOURS THAT CHANGED LOS ANGELES

BY LAURA J. NELSON

As the sun rose Jan. 8, the sky orange from ash and smoke, Angelenos anxiously waited for news about the extent of the damage from the Altadena and Pacific Palisades fires.

It would take days to learn that the conflagrations had caused an unprecedented level of destruction, killing at least 28 people, destroying and damaging more than 18,000 structures valued at more than \$275 billion, and leaving a burn zone 2 ½ times the size of Manhattan. That for decades to come, the disaster would divide our history into a “before” and “after.”

Here is how those first 24 hours unfolded.

[See **24 hours**, A8]



WALLY SKALIJ Los Angeles Times



ETHAN SWOPE Associated Press

AT LEFT, a firefighter battles the Palisades fire as homes burn along Pacific Coast Highway in Malibu. At right, residents of an Altadena senior care facility are evacuated during the Eaton fire on Jan. 7.

Through smoke, ash and embers

As fire bore down, nursing home workers pushed or carried 45 patients to safety.

STEVE LOPEZ

Juana Rodriguez, administrator of Two Palms Care Center in Altadena, had just returned to his home in Riverside. She washed up, prepared to eat dinner with her family, and then got an urgent call from her on-duty nurse.



Fire was approaching the facility, home to 45 elderly and disabled patients ranging in age from mid-60s to 103, many of them bedridden, some with dementia.

“I just grabbed my things, and I told my family I was leaving to go back to work because we might need to evacuate,” Rodriguez said.

That same evening, Tony Moya, administrator of Golden Legacy Care Center, a sister agency in Sylmar, had just returned to his Sunland home when a colleague texted to ask how many beds were available for evacuees.

Moya, who served in the Marine Corps and was part of Operation Desert Storm in the Gulf War of 1991, stepped outside to return to work. But the wind was

[See Lopez, A10]



Los Angeles Times photo illustration; photographs by JASON ARMOND / Los Angeles Times and courtesy of BRIAN JAMES, ALLYSON CARLISLE and MICAH COLEMAN

Decades of Black history lost

Against the odds, many bought homes and thrived for generations in Altadena, an imperfect paradise largely destroyed by Eaton fire

By Brittney Mejia

The four-bedroom home on Highview Avenue that Olsen J. Rogers bought in 1963 was a far cry from the Texas farm given to his family by the man who enslaved his grandmother.

The two-bedroom house along East Altadena Drive was purchased by William “BJ” Ransom James on a predominantly Black cul-de-sac in 1968. He worked three jobs to help pay it off.

And the four-bedroom house on North Lake Avenue was where Blossom Powe, originally from St. Louis, raised her children in integrated schools in 1973 and wrote poetry about being Black in America.

These homes and other structures were monuments to the Black residents drawn to Altadena, first as domestic workers in the estates of millionaires and later as a rising middle class of profession-

als who had broken glass ceilings.

Altadena, population nearly 42,000, is the town where the Rev. Martin Luther King Jr. once visited lawyer Clarence B. Jones to persuade him to join his legal team. Where sci-fi author Octavia E. Butler is buried alongside abolitionists. Where a park is named after Charles White, a local artist whose work portrayed Black history.

“You’re talking about generations of families that have lived there,” former Vice President Kamala Harris said at a recent breakfast celebrating King — and mourning Altadena. They were “some of the first hardworking Black families who were able to buy property in California and then pass down those homes through generations.”

Then the Eaton fire came, [See **Altadena**, A6]

For many, orders arrived too late

In some parts of Altadena, alerts came well after smoke and flames threatened.

By TERRY CASTLEMAN, GRACE TOOHEY, AND BRITTNY MEJIA

During the night of the devastating Eaton fire, Altadena resident Araceli Cabrera and her partner remained on edge as they monitored the county’s Genasys emergency communications app.

“I’m looking at the app and we’re good,” Cabrera, 52, recalled her partner saying well into the night. But around 4:30 a.m. on Jan. 8 — about 10 hours after the fire ignited — Cabrera saw a photo shared on Facebook of several fires burning within blocks of their western Altadena home. She and her partner looked outside in a panic.

“All of a sudden it was completely black and I saw the embers — part of me couldn’t believe it,” Cabrera said. “I felt like I was going to die if I didn’t hurry.”

The couple frantically decided to flee their home, yet it would be at least another hour before emergency management officials issued an evacuation order for their neighborhood. They ended up, like so many others, losing their home.

“I feel like different agencies failed us,” Cabrera said. “Nowhere did they say the fire was moving faster, they didn’t tell anyone to evacuate. ... It was like we were abandoned.”

Stories like Cabrera’s have ricocheted around Altadena in recent days as residents compare notes about evacuation orders that were issued hours after the massive Eaton fire ignited and — in some cases, after neighborhoods had already begun to burn and well after other nearby areas were ordered to leave.

The Times reported earlier last week that thousands of people living west of North Lake Avenue first got electronic evacuation orders around 3:30 a.m., well after smoke and flames were threatening the area. All 17 people who died in the Altadena firestorm lived west of

[See **Complaints**, A9]

Hegseth wins confirmation

Despite concerns about qualifications, he is confirmed as Pentagon chief as VP breaks a tie. **NATION, A4**

Feeling slighted in Altadena

Victims say Trump should have also toured their area hit by Eaton fire during his visit. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Remembering Kobe Bryant

Bill Plaschke and readers honor late Lakers superstar on the fifth anniversary of his tragic death. **SPORTS, D1**

Weather

Cool, with rain. L.A. Basin: 55/44. **B10**

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In this together: Black Los Angeles mobilizes to offer support to fire survivors. **WEEKEND, L6**